

Nero Express is a user-friendly interface that provides easy access to all features. Nero 6 supports almost all the popular CD formats, even the HFS file system.

A disadvantage with Nero 6 was its lack of the network browsing feature—you need to use the Windows browser to burn files onto your network CDs. You can easily create ISO images, and can burn bootable and regular CDs from ISO and CUE images. A novel feature is its support for Mini DVD discs—you can write onto these small DVD discs which hold up to 1.4 GB of data. It also supports multiple recorders—so you can create multiple copies of a disc simultaneously—as well as packet-writing, through IN CD or Direct CD for convenient drag-and-drop CD-writing. Another good feature in Nero 6, is the addition of a virus-checker and a backup tool. You can even create your own copy protected audio CDs using Nero 6—this excellent feature is absent in all other software; the same goes

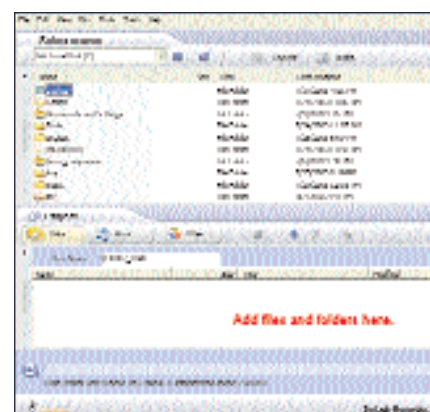
for its virus checking feature. By adding a new, improved interface, Nero has become more appealing to new users—but it is not as user-friendly as NTI or Easy CD/DVD. For advanced users, it supports several pleasing options such as overburning, changing buffer size and so on.

Easy CD/ DVD Creator 6

Easy CD/DVD Creator 6 from Roxio is the most user-friendly CD-writing software available today, and it also sports the best-looking interface. It consists of five separate utilities bundled into a nice package, with a common interface to start from. These five are Disc Copier, Audio Central, DVD Builder, Photosuite and Creator classic. Disc Copier allows you to create exact copies of any CD. Audio Central is a powerful tool for playing, encoding and editing audio files. DVD Builder is a complete video authoring tool for creating VCDs and DVDs. It has support for video capture

Writing CDs over a Network

It is possible to write CDs remotely from a single machine over a network. This is where client-server technology comes in. The server software runs on the machines with burner capabilities, and the client software runs on all the user machines. The image to be burned is created at the user machine, and sent over the network for writing. One software that supports this functionality is NeroNET that is available as a standalone application from Ahead Software.



Easy CD/ DVD Creator features an extremely easy-to-use file browser interface

from DV camcorders and from VHS tapes, too. With Photosuite, you can capture, edit and organise any type of image easily. Creator Classic is just the usual Explorer-type interface, but for advanced users.

Easy CD/ DVD Creator supports ISO file writing, but does not support CUE files. It supports disc spanning for larger files, and it has a tool for browsing files spanned onto different discs, which is useful for copying the files back onto your hard disk. It has packet writing, with a drop-in-basket interface that sits in your system tray. For writing to your CD-RW, all you have to do is drag-and-drop a file into this basket, and the software takes care of the rest. Overall, Easy CD/ DVD Creator is best suited for capturing videos, editing them and writing them onto VCDs.

NTI CD-Maker 6 Platinum

This is yet another CD-writing software targeted at first-time users. It has a friendly interface, and you can access all the features with a couple of mouse-clicks. The file browser is user-friendly, and also supports network browsing. It does not have

Jargon Buster

Hybrid CD: A CD that's readable by both MACs and PCs. It is created by making a copy of each file in both, the ISO (for PC) and HFS (for MAC) formats.

HFS CD: HFS CDs can be read only by Apple computers. To create a HFS CD, you need to use a hard disk with the HFS file system connected to a PC, and a CD-writing software that supports the file system such as Nero 6.

Mixed Mode CD: A CD that contains a data track, and one or more audio tracks. The data is located in track number one, and audio in the following tracks.

UDF: A file system that is optimised to handle large data sizes, and to minimise the changes necessary when a file is added or deleted. Windows 98 and higher versions can write to and read from the UDF file system, without any special driver support. This is the best format for DVD-RW drives where the data size goes into GBs.

Simulation: This is the process of testing the recording process without actually doing so. The writing is done by sending the data to the recorder, whilst keeping the laser off. This way, the blank CD remains intact. Simulation is used to check if the recording will be successful.

CD Extra: A CD format that combines a music CD with a regular data CD-ROM. These discs have audio tracks in the first part, and computer data in the second. You can play the discs on music players,

and also use them as regular data CDs.

Overburning: A technique by which you burn more data onto a CD than its specified capacity. For overburning, the CD recorder should support this feature, and the writing should be done in the 'Disc-at-once' mode. How much data can be overburned, depends on the medium and the recorder.

DDCD: Expanding to mean Double Density CD, it allows data capacity to be doubled to 1.3 GB. DDCD is made possible by a few simple modifications to the regular CD format, such as miniaturisation of track pitch and minimum pit length. DDCD is mainly targeted at the mass data backup segment. The media is not backward compatible.

TAO: It refers to Track At Once CD-writing. In this method, a gap of 2 seconds is introduced between tracks at the time of writing to ensure proper synchronisation, and to conform to standards. During these gaps, the laser is turned off for 2 seconds.

DAO: In the Disc At Once method, the laser is never turned off, and hence no gap or delay is necessary. This mode is much faster than Track At Once, but the recorder should support it.

SAO: Session at Once is the mode used in multi-session CD-writing. In this mode, a session is written without turning off the laser just as in DAO, but the session is closed only after the data and the ToC are written into the Program Memory Area.